

Digital Sovereignty - a modest proposal

A Vision, and a Path We Have Already Started Walking

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Every day, someone even in a remote region like Kashmir borrows a library book through an app, a farmer cooperative logs a harvest, a student's record is updated at school. Each of these small acts of digital life is quietly stored on a server none of us own, reachable under a law none of us wrote. This note lays out what a different path looks like, and why the coming few years are the right window to start building it.

1 The uncomfortable fact we live with every day

Roughly two-thirds of the world's cloud computing spend is concentrated in three American companies.¹ Nearly every app, portal, or database a small organisation in Kashmir builds today ends up running, physically and legally, on one of their machines — regardless of which country the data center itself sits in. Since 2018, US law has required any American company to hand over data on government request, no matter where in the world the server holding it is located. A platform advertising “data residency in India” on top of American infrastructure is offering a comforting label, not sovereignty.

Can a small group of ambitious youth and talented students make a difference? Can we contribute to laying the foundation of something that will enable people to dream of disentangling themselves from the chains of Western corporate digital supremacy? The answer is an unflinching yes—but only if we stop waiting for the perfect and convenient solution and start building.

The question was never whether we depend on digital infrastructure — we already do, every day, for things that matter. The real question is: whose infrastructure, under whose law, and who profits from it.

2 What sovereignty actually means here

This is not an argument for disconnecting, nor for reinventing technology that already works well. It is an argument about ownership of a small number of foundational layers—where things are hosted, who hands over our data and to whom, and what happens to a community's data if a distant vendor changes its terms or raises its price.

¹Indicative figures based on public analyst estimates (Synergy Research Group, Canalys, 2025–26 market share reporting).

The vision is a shared, open technical foundation—the basic plumbing that almost any digital service needs: a place to store data safely, a way to verify who a user is, a way to keep files, and a way to keep the lights on when the grid or the network falters. Built once, built openly, and hosted on infrastructure that this region actually owns & controls. Any local institution that needs a digital presence—a library, a farmer cooperative, a clinic keeping patient records, a school archiving its own history, or even our moments, stories, pictures & videos—should be able to build on that foundation, rather than each independently renting the same dependency from the same distant companies.

Two design choices make this realistic rather than idealistic. First, every layer of this foundation will be built from open, freely licensed software, so no single vendor—foreign or local—can hold it hostage. Second, it is designed to be regional rather than purely local: resilient when any one city or building loses power or connectivity, yet never dependent on foreign jurisdiction.

3 Proof before promise: what is already being built

This vision is not starting from a blank page, and it should not be mistaken for a purely hypothetical ask. Small, independent projects are already live and already serving real people in the region. The latest *Marsiya* App, built by the Dreamer's Institute, is one such example. A community library portal is another, already handling real book donations, loans, and requests for real users. Neither was built as a grand infrastructure statement — each simply set out to solve one concrete, local problem, and did.

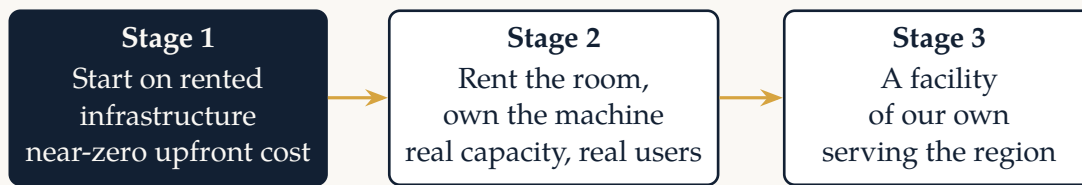
What these early projects have in common matters more than any one of them individually: each was built by a small local team with limited resources, and each currently rents its underlying infrastructure from the very same distant platforms this note describes as the long-term problem. They are proof that the demand is real and the technical skill to build for it already exists here. What they do not yet have is a shared, regionally owned home to run on. OLK's current technical stack and database structure are open source from top to bottom—and ready to be hosted on a local server.²

That is the opportunity in front of us: not to start a first project, but to give the projects that already exist — and the ones that have not been imagined yet — a foundation that belongs to this region, so that scaling one of them up, or starting the next one, is no longer a decision that has to be made one distant subscription at a time.

4 The path: three stages, not one leap

Owning meaningful infrastructure sounds like it requires a large facility and a large budget on day one. It does not. The realistic path is staged, and each stage is deliberately sized to the confidence and resources available at that point.

²To be discussed in detail in our upcoming meeting.



In the first stage, services run on infrastructure rented cheaply from outside the region, at near-zero upfront cost, while the team behind them builds the operational skills — running servers, keeping backups, monitoring uptime — that every later stage depends on. In the second stage, the team moves to renting physical space, power, and connectivity inside an existing facility, while the server hardware itself belongs to us. This is where a real pilot lands: capable of serving tens of thousands of users, not a demonstration. In the third stage, the region has its own dedicated facility, with redundant power and connectivity, serving as shared infrastructure for many local institutions at once.

The point of staging it this way is that nothing gets thrown away as we advance. Every stage runs the same open software, on the same foundation, for the same projects. Moving from one stage to the next is an upgrade, not a rebuild — which means a modest first step is not a compromise on the vision, it is the fastest honest route toward it.

5 Why now

Three trends are converging in a way that makes this the right moment, not an early one.

The physical foundation is catching up. Reliability of the regional power grid has been improving; efficient UPS systems are becoming affordable; and integrating renewable sources has not only become realistic but is also highly encouraged by existing policies—closing a gap that would have made this proposal premature not long ago.

The software layer has matured. The open-source tools needed to run this kind of shared infrastructure—databases, authentication, storage, hosting—are now mature, well documented, and designed to be self-hosted from day one. Building on them today is a matter of deployment and operations, not unproven research.

The community already exists. As the previous section showed, the builders, the demand, and the early proof points are not hypothetical—they are already here, scattered across a handful of small independent projects. What is missing is not talent or appetite. It is a shared foundation, and the modest resources needed to start building it deliberately rather than accidentally.

We are not choosing between staying dependent and building a data center overnight. We are choosing the order in which we build confidence, skill, and capability—starting now, with what we already have.

6 An invitation

This note is deliberately brief, and deliberately light on the engineering detail behind it. That detail exists, has been worked through to a large extent, and will be presented—with a concrete first-stage plan, a realistic budget, and a clear list of the roles and skills still needed—at the presentation this note is meant to introduce.

If the argument above resonates—that each region should own the infrastructure its community life increasingly depends on; that the pieces to start doing so are closer at hand than they might seem; and, most importantly, that it can be efficiently built by our youth and students—then the invitation is simple: come, be part of the plan, and help decide what gets built next.

Our data. Our servers. Our region. **Let's begin.**